



Amber

△ Polished amber containing a preserved spider

The fossilized tree resin from a prehistoric pine tree that was common in the Baltics, amber is also found in a few other locations. True amber is around 25–60 million years old, and specimens can function as tiny time capsules, preserving long-extinct plants and insects – these are highly valued. The Greeks noted how amber becomes charged when rubbed with fur or wool; the word for amber in Greek, *elektron*, is the root of the word “electricity”. Amber has a low density and can float on salt water, so it is often found along seashores.

Specification

Chemical name Oxygenated hydrocarbon | **Formula** Organic
Colours White, yellow, orange, red, brown, blue, black, green
Structure Amorphous | **Hardness** 2–2.5 | **SG** 1.05–1.09
RI 1.54 | **Lustre** Resinous | **Streak** White | **Locations**
Eastern Europe, Dominican Republic, USA

Rough

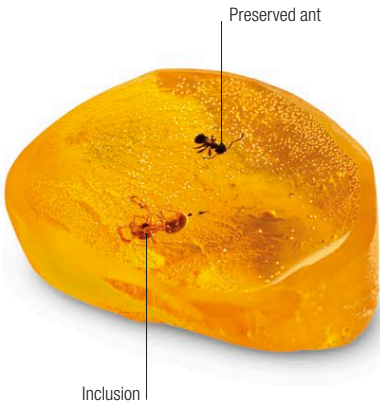


Opaque surface

Amber rough | In common with many amber roughs, the luminously transparent interior of this piece of amber is visible behind its opaque surface.

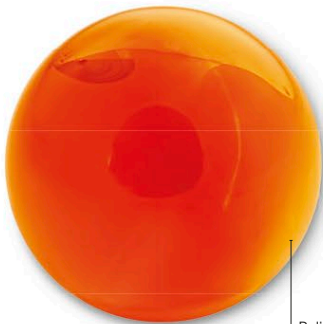


Broken rough | This amber nodule has been broken, revealing the fine-quality amber within the dull, textured exterior that is typical of amber in its natural state.



Clear amber | This piece of clear amber contains a preserved insect and other inclusions. It has been smoothed to a natural finish by the elements.

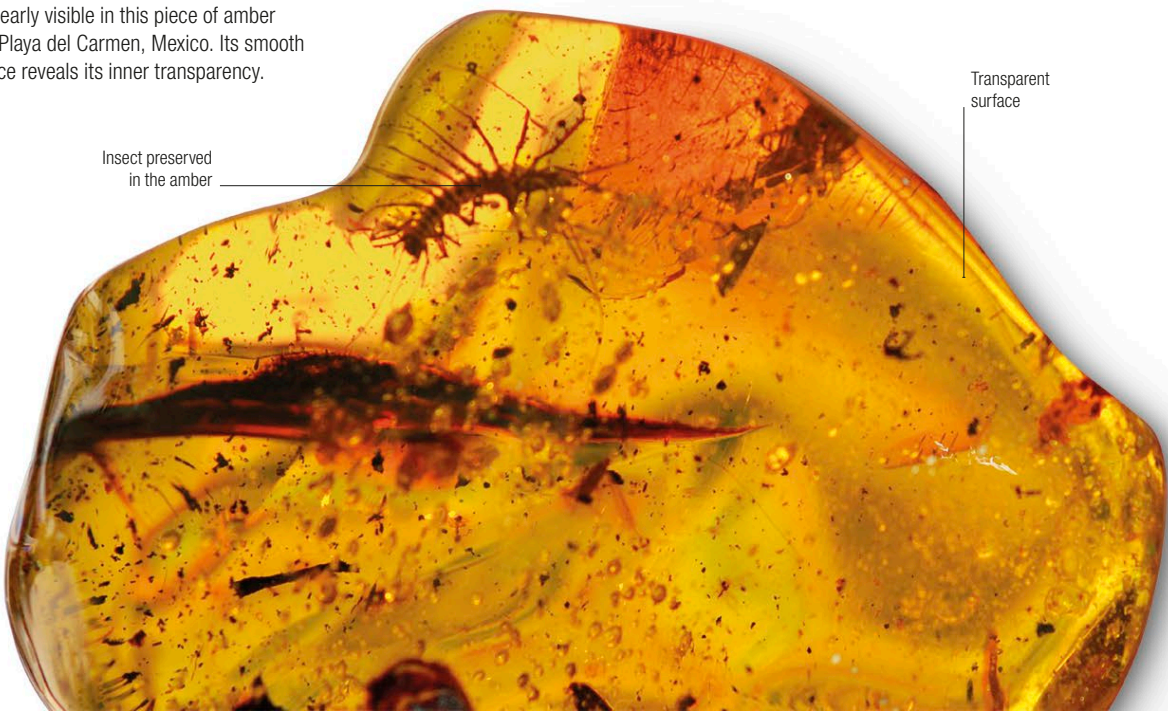
Cut



Polished finish

Amber sphere | This finely polished spherical amber bead shows a deep orange colour and opaque texture. It originates from the southeastern coast of the Baltic.

Polished specimen | Preserved insects are clearly visible in this piece of amber from Playa del Carmen, Mexico. Its smooth surface reveals its inner transparency.



Unusual coloration



Faceted amber | Amber is rarely faceted because of its extreme fragility. The cutter of this 2.36-carat emerald-cut green amber stone was unusually skilful.